

they are living in shame because they are weak in the eyes of the people who live in the area, who can come into their city and steal from them.

Imagine being away from home and you hear that your home is not safe from harm. There are people who wish to do harm to the people you love back home. You thought they were protected, but you learn that they're not. They are in serious danger.

Nehemiah goes into a period of mourning. He is completely beside himself. This goes on for days. He cries. He prays. He tells God that he knows the people had disobeyed God, and that God had allowed for their punishment. God's plans could not be stopped. We read it: ⁸ "Remember the word that you commanded your servant Moses, saying, 'If you are unfaithful, I will scatter you among the peoples, ⁹ but if you return to me and keep my commandments and do them, though your outcasts are in the uttermost parts of heaven, from there I will gather them and bring them to the place that I have chosen, to make my name dwell there.'"

What words had God spoken to Moses?

¹ "And when all these things come upon you, the blessing and the curse, which I have set before you, and you call them to mind among all the nations where the LORD your God has driven you, ² and return to the LORD your God, you and your children, and obey his voice in all that I command you today, with all your heart and with all your soul, ³ then the LORD your God will restore your fortunes and have mercy on you, and he will gather you again from all the peoples where the LORD your God has scattered you. ⁴ If your outcasts are in the uttermost parts of heaven, from there the LORD your God will gather you, and from there he will take you. ⁵ And the LORD your God will bring you into the land that your fathers possessed, that you may possess it. And he will make you more prosperous and numerous than your fathers. Deuteronomy 30:1–5 (ESV)

God had known in advance that the people of Israel would disobey Him. He knew in advance that they would be sent into exile. Here God had promised them that when these things took place that He would bring them back to the land if and when they repented. Nehemiah was asking God to honor His promise.

This request from Nehemiah raises another concern: Did the people truly repent? When we ended the book of Ezra we saw that Ezra had called the people to repent for their worship of false gods, which had taken place when they married people who worshipped false gods. They had joined their spouses in their worship of false gods. To stop this the people had pledged to give up their wives and husbands who worshipped the false gods. But had they kept their promise to God? We will see.

In Nehemiah 1:11 we learn that Nehemiah is the cup bearer to the king of Babylon. Nehemiah's concern for the wellbeing of his fellow Jews affects his work. In chapter 2 we learn that Nehemiah lets his feelings show when he is serving the king. This was very dangerous for Nehemiah. People who served the king were supposed to act like they were so happy to be in the presence of the king that nothing else mattered. If a person wasn't happy when serving the king, they could be executed because they weren't showing a sense of joy. They let something in their life mean more to themselves than their job of serving the king. They should be glad to have such a good job.

Yet, instead of being angry with Nehemiah, the king takes a personal interest in Nehemiah's concern for his people in Jerusalem. The king sends Nehemiah to Jerusalem to make sure things are going well. Not only that, eventually the king makes Nehemiah the governor of Jerusalem (Nehemiah 5:14).

Being Home

The king gives Nehemiah papers so that his trip to Jerusalem is allowed by all the people in the area. When he gets home, or to his new home in Jerusalem. Three days after he arrives, he walked through the city in the middle of the night. He probably did this at night so that no one knew what he was doing. What he learns shocks him, even though he had been told about it. Not only is one gate of the city destroyed, every gate into the city has been destroyed. The city is at great risk. Anyone with a band of men could enter the city and do pretty much whatever they wanted.

Listen to what happened next:

¹⁷ Then I said to them, "You see the trouble we are in, how Jerusalem lies in ruins with its gates burned. Come, let us build the wall of Jerusalem, that we may no longer suffer derision." ¹⁸ And I told them of the hand of my God that had been upon me for good, and also of the words that the king had spoken to me. And they said, "Let us rise up and build." So they strengthened their hands for the good work. ¹⁹ But

when Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah the Ammonite servant and Geshem the Arab heard of it, they jeered at us and despised us and said, "What is this thing that you are doing? Are you rebelling against the king?"²⁰ Then I replied to them, "The God of heaven will make us prosper, and we his servants will arise and build, but you have no portion or right or claim in Jerusalem." Nehemiah 2:17–20 (ESV)

Immediately, Nehemiah gets the leaders of the city to begin building strong gates for the city. The king had given Nehemiah authorization to get the timbers needed to build the gates (Nehemiah 2:8). Obviously, some of the leaders of the area near Jerusalem aren't pleased. But Nehemiah isn't intimidated. He knows that God's hand is on him and the work he is doing (And I told them of the hand of my God that had been upon me for good, and also of the words that the king had spoken to me," from Nehemiah 2:18).

Making a Home

Because God's hand is on Nehemiah, he has the approval of the king of Babylon. But there are problems. First, the leaders around Jerusalem oppose the work. We just read about that in Nehemiah 2:19 (But when Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah the Ammonite servant and Geshem the Arab heard of it, they jeered at us and despised us and said, "What is this thing that you are doing? Are you rebelling against the king?"). In chapter 4 we learn that the problems got even more intense. The men who worked had weapons either in one hand or strapped to their side. Some were set aside to be soldiers who didn't do any of the work of building the gates or walls (Nehemiah 4:16-18).

A second problem was that the Jewish people had problems of their own. The rich people were lending money at interest. That may not seem like a strange thing to us. However, the needs of the poor people were very great and lending them money at interest was severely damaging the whole community. Nehemiah put a stop to it (Nehemiah 5:10-12).

It was a hot mess! There were enemies outside of the Jewish community who wanted to destroy the small group of Jewish people. And there were rich people within the community who were selfishly getting richer on the backs of the poorest people. Nehemiah demanded that they needed to make sacrifices for the need of the whole community.

For Nehemiah getting home was not the total solution for all the problems. When he arrived he had to struggle to find the right way to solve all the problems. It wasn't easy. It took a lot of very hard work. I'm sure there were some people who were angry with him but he did what he knew was right.

You may have big plans of your own for what you will do when you get home. You need to bring those plans before God in prayer. Ask Him to show you what you need to do. When you get home you will run into difficulties that you can't anticipate now. You can't have it all figured out yet. You will need to go to God again and again in prayer seeking His solution. His plans cannot be stopped. If your plans don't match God's plans they aren't going to happen.

One of the best things you can do is to become part of a group of genuine believers who really love God. You need to become part of a church. You need to seek their help so that you will stay in a right relationship with God.

If you do what is displeasing to God you need to repent and turn back to God. Nehemiah urged the leaders of Jerusalem to stop oppressing the poor people. You need to make sure you are not oppressing people around yourself. If you learn that you are terrorizing friends, family, or neighbors then you need to repent and seek God's forgiveness.

Husbands are called by God to love their wives (Ephesians 5:25, 28, Colossians 3:19). Parents are told to discipline their children so that they will know right from wrong and do what is right (Proverbs 22:6). Fathers are told that they should discipline their sons and daughters in such a way that their children don't end up resenting them for being overly harsh (Ephesians 6:4; Colossians 3:21).

God has a plan for this entire universe. Every believer will be a part of God's glorious, eternal plan. We may think we want to be the boss and do our own thing. But God's plan has one very important thing going for it. It can't fail. Wouldn't you rather be part of a plan that can't fail than to be part of a plan that can't succeed?

God knew His people would never be able to obey Him in everything they did. He provided a Savior, His one and only Son, Jesus Christ. Jesus died on the cross to pay the price of every believer's sin. When we believe in Jesus, we become part of God's glorious, eternal plan.

The need for God's forgiveness is present in our homes. We need God's help. Loving those who are closest to us is not easy. Pray for God's help. Seek God's forgiveness and grace. He will see you through — ⁶ And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ," Philippians 1:6 (ESV).

Nehemiah Prays for the Sons of Israel (Nehemiah 1:1–11)

T O R E Y A R P E O P L E
D E V I V R U S H Y R V V
T O T R C H A N A N I M X
L H X W H E C R G T H O O
D N E K E E P H N D A S H
E E G R L N X E I T C E A
N H D G E U T A N S A S S
E E L N D T S I R V L S U
P M E L A S U R E J I E S
P I A X T M L N C T A R V
A A R N I X M O N T H V H
H H S Y C L H O O R P A A
S N I S N I E Y C Y T N D
L O R D G D E G R E A T C

The words of **Nehemiah** the son of **Hacaliah**. Now it **happened** in the **month** of **Chislev**, in the **twentieth** year, as I was in **Susa** the **citadel**, that **Hanani**, one of my brothers, came with certain men from Judah. And I asked them **concerning** the Jews who escaped, who had **survived** the **exile**, and **concerning Jerusalem**. And they **said** to me, "The remnant **there** in the province who had **survived** the **exile** is in **great** trouble and shame. The wall of **Jerusalem** is broken down, and its gates are destroyed by fire." As soon as I heard these words I sat down and wept and mourned for days, and I continued fasting and **praying** before the God of **heaven**. And I **said**, "O **LORD** God of **heaven**, the **great** and awesome God who **keeps** covenant and steadfast **love** with those who **love** him and **keep** his **commandments**, let your ear be **attentive** and your eyes open, to hear the **prayer** of your **servant** that I now **pray** before you day and night for the **people** of **Israel** your **servants**, confessing the **sins** of the **people** of **Israel**, which we have **sinned** against you. Even I and my father's house have **sinned**. We have acted very corruptly against you and have not kept the **commandments**, the statutes, and the rules that you **commanded** your **servant Moses**. Remember the word that you **commanded** your **servant Moses**, saying, 'If you are unfaithful, I will scatter you among the **peoples**, but if you return to me and **keep** my **commandments** and do them, though your outcasts are in the uttermost parts of **heaven**, from **there** I will gather them and bring them to the place that I have chosen, to make my **name** dwell **there**.' They are your **servants** and your **people**, whom you have redeemed by your **great** power and by your strong hand. O **Lord**, let your ear be **attentive** to the **prayer** of your **servant**, and to the **prayer** of your **servants** who delight to fear your **name**, and give success to your **servant** today, and grant him mercy in the sight of this man." Now I was cupbearer to the king.

(ESV)

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